

DOCTORING ADMISSIONS

A cash-for-seat scandal reveals how easy it is to use unscrupulous means—impersonation, money and power—to mark an entry into the much revered medical profession these days

Photographs by SUBIR HALDER



■ By Swagata Sen and Sanjay Bhadra

Ranvijay Pathak and Mihir Jha could have got all their creature comforts in a few years had they studied hard to become qualified doctors. Or perhaps, too inspired by *Munnabhai MBBS*, they wanted instant gratification. The result was a can of worms that rocked the entire state medical entrance establishment, throwing up new names and arrests everyday.

In just two weeks' time, the state police have arrested 15 people in what appears to be the biggest education scandal—cash-for-seat. At the centre of the scam are Jha, an ex-student of Calcutta Medical College and Pathak, a fourth year medical student, with Ayan Mukherjee, who is an intern. Although the police is still unsure of the exact

number, investigations show that the racket has helped more than 80 students secure admission in various medical colleges all over the country. "So far, we have received information only about medical colleges. But we suspect it extends to other colleges as well," says Ajoy Kumar, chief of Kolkata's Detective Department.

In June this year, a students' organisation had intimated the state Health Minister Surya Kanta Mishra, about discrepancies in the results of medical entrance examinations. According to them, out of 1,105 successful candidates in the exams, the names of at least 28 didn't tally in the two lists. The police say on the slated day, the board withheld the initial result for three hours, and a new list which differed from the original was displayed. The board had apparently been tipped-off

IN THE NET: Among the arrested are medical students

about some of the suspect candidates from other states, especially Bihar, and had started an enquiry even before the admit-cards were issued. It has not yet given the police the list of the suspects.

Both Jha's and Pathak's lifestyles were being watched closely after the police received an anonymous letter in mid-June, stating their alleged involvement in the scandal.

The trio had networked with various coaching centres in Kolkata, Durgapur, Bangalore and Varanasi, among other cities. These coaching centres worked as agents, and would use newspapers as a medium to advertise claims of "high success rates" or "guaranteed success" in the entrance examinations. Once they had lured a gullible candidate, they would